## 8.4 Breast feeding

Breast feeding should be initiated as soon as after birth of the baby. A baby is usually alert immediately after birth which is the ideal time to facilitate breast feeding. The baby will spontaneously seek the breast if it is put on skin to skin contact with its mother's body. Breast milk is the best milk, suited for a newborn. It contains all the nutrients for the normal growth and development of a baby from birth to first six months of life.

### Exclusive Breast feeding

In exclusive breast feeding, the infant is given only breast milk. Even the water is not given – with the exception of oral rehydration solution, or drops/syrups of vitamins, minerals or medicines.




Healthy neonates when placed skin to skin on their mother's tummy and chest after birth, shows amazing behaviours. The baby moves, crawls, smells and licks the mothers nipple. Finally, the baby on its own attaches to the breast and feeds.

The first milk secreted from the breast is known as colostrum, also called the baby's 'first vaccine' as well as considered as **"liquid gold"** which is extremely rich in nutrients and antibodies.

### WHO recommendations on Breast feeding

Babies should be **exclusively** breast fed for the **first 6 months** of life to achieve optimal growth, development and health. Thereafter, infants should be given complementary foods which are nutritionally adequate and safe to meet their nutritional requirements,while continuing to breastfeed for up to two years or beyond.

### Advantages of Breast feeding

#### For babies

- It is safe, clean and hygienic
- It is cheap and available in correct temperature to the infant
- It completely meets the nutritional requirement of infants upto 6 months
- It provides immunity to the infants
- It protects babies from diarrhoea and respiratory infection
- It is easily digestible
- It promotes bonding between the mother and infant
- It prevents under nutrition as well as over nutrition
- It reduces the risk of overweight and obesity in children
- It increases the Intelligence Quotient of the babies
- It ensures food security for the babies

#### For the mother

- Breast feeding delays next pregnancy
- It lowers risk of breast and ovarian cancer
- It decreases mother's work load

#### For the family and society

- Breast feeding saves money
- It promotes family planning
- It decreases the need for hospitalization



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